

SUPRANATIONAL FEDERALISM

The World Citizens' Journal

For a dialogue between peoples, nations and civilizations



**THE ALTIERO SPINELLI INSTITUTE
FOR FEDERALIST STUDIES**

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"It's good to live where humanity reigns. Those who choose to reside in a place devoid of humanity lack wisdom. ... Do not do to others what you would not want them to do to you." (Confucius, *The Analects*, 4.1; 15.24).

Nowadays young people wonder if they will have a future. A nuclear war between great powers can annihilate the population of entire continents. Moreover, all living organisms, including humanity, are threatened by an irreversible ecological crisis of the biosphere. The international political system created at the end of the Second World War is paralyzed by hostilities between large and small powers pursuing conflicting goals and interests. No world player proposes to stop the mad race towards a fatal international anarchy.

However, the federalists can act. About half of the world's population lives in federal states, but in these countries, federalism is conceived as a technique of administrative decentralization. On the contrary, in Europe, since the Schuman Declaration of 1950, the European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC) has been conceived as "the first step towards the European Federation." European and world federalists can act together for a just and peaceful international order, founded on democratically legitimized supranational institutions.

International pacification is necessary to stop the environmental crisis, the arms race and war. The first step is to start a dialogue between all national peoples and civilizations on the future of the international order. The European Union, "by creating an area of freedom, security and justice," has established the European citizenship. Why not establish the same form of peaceful coexistence for the citizens of the world?

Submissions – The "Supranational Federalism" Journal is open to all citizens of the world who wish to develop arguments and observations on the international political process in the spirit indicated in the mission statement above. The contribution must be written in English. The Journal will be published every three months. Each contribution must not exceed the limit of 1,500 words and must be sent to the following address: supranational.federalism@gmail.com. We encourage young people to submit articles. Submission must include a short biography and a photo of the author. Please do not include footnotes, endnotes, or references; instead provide hyperlinks for any references you think would be helpful. We reserve the right to make editorial changes before publication.

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The figure on the front page - with twelve portraits that have been chosen as personalities who have indicated to future generations the founding values of a cosmopolitan civilization - is the work of the graphic designer Alice Lazzaro: alicelazzaroart@gmail.com

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Ideas for the World’s Citizens Corner

Published at the Request of the Editor

In memory of Jürgen Habermas

“Federal Bridges” – The Need for a United front for Peace in the Middle East

by Yair Gorni

At a time when the Israeli–Palestinian conflict appears trapped between a deteriorating status quo and increasingly extreme alternatives; it becomes necessary to return to first principles and re-examine the range of solutions that have historically been considered viable. Rather than viewing peace as a binary choice between separation and unity, this article argues that a more nuanced approach—grounded in shared sovereignty, regional integration, and gradual institutional cooperation—offers a realistic pathway forward. By revisiting past proposals and situating them within contemporary realities, we can begin to outline a framework capable of transforming conflict into a sustainable and inclusive political order.

In contemporary Israel, the shattered political peace camp is far from monolithic. It is broadly divided into three principal currents. The first are the Two-States, represented by frameworks such as the Geneva Initiative, who advocate ending the occupation through a negotiated partition into two sovereign states. The second are the Federalists, like our own movement Atid-Fed, who argue that long-term stability requires shared institutions and gradual integration alongside sovereignty. The third are the Regionalists, associated with trends emerging from the Abraham Accords and broader “Abrahamic” thinking, who believe that Israeli–Palestinian peace is unlikely to succeed in isolation and must be embedded within a wider regional framework of normalization and cooperation. While these approaches often appear to compete, they in fact reflect different emphases on sovereignty, interdependence, and regional context.

If we look at the solutions from the early history of the conflict, we can see that most peace initiatives shared a common principle: the simultaneous rejection of a unitary state and of full separation. The various plans proposed—by Zionists, by the British, and by elements within the Palestinian-Arab leadership that opposed the rigid unitary line of Hajj Amin al-Husseini—generally revolved around two principal frameworks that followed this logic.

For example, the 1937 Peel Commission proposed partitioning the land into two states, yet envisioned them as linked through economic and security arrangements, and linked to a greater regional alliance, therefore was not based on full separation. By contrast, the 1945 Morrison–Grady Plan formally proposed a single political framework, but one divided into three cantons: a Jewish canton along the coastal plain and northern valleys; an Arab canton in the Galilee, southern coastal areas, and the expanded Judea and Samaria highlands; and a non-contiguous shared canton including Jerusalem and the Negev; therefore, was clearly un-unitary.

Similarly, the United Nations Special Committee on Palestine (UNSCOP) presented two alternatives: a majority plan for two independent states, and a minority plan for a federal state composed of a Jewish canton and an Arab canton. Yet even the “two states” majority option included clear confederal elements—economic union, freedom of movement, and joint management of key areas such as Jerusalem—while the minority “federal state” plan was still grounded in a dual-national structure.

This pattern is also evident in the most advanced rounds of Israeli–Palestinian negotiations in recent decades. Proposals discussed under leaders such as Ehud Barak and Ehud Olmert with Yasser Arafat and Mahmoud Abbas, as well as in civil society frameworks like the Geneva Initiative, were never based on full separation. On the contrary, they consistently incorporated mechanisms of cooperation—joint water management, coordinated airspace, security arrangements, and elements of economic integration and movement—often framed within the broader vision of a “New Middle East,” associated with Shimon Peres. This logic was further echoed at the regional level in initiatives such as the Arab Peace Initiative. Together, these elements reflect a continued recognition that even a two-state framework must rest on structured interdependence rather than strict disengagement.

These solutions share a clear common denominator: *full recognition of the right to self-determination of both peoples, alongside a dual rejection—both of a unitary state and of complete separation. Instead, they consistently sought to balance sovereignty with interdependence. This principle must serve as a foundational guideline for any movement seeking to advance genuine peace.*

Any attempt to impose a unitary state by force is likely in practice to result in an ethnocratic regime dominated by one side—akin to French Algeria or apartheid South Africa—alternatively a theocratic regime, as seen in Iran or Afghanistan, or simply a military dictator by one of the two groups over the other. At the same time, the historical record demonstrates that full separation was never considered viable either. Even attempts to establish a formally “equal civic state” based on post-colonial models, without a shared social and political infrastructure—as demonstrated by Cyprus prior to 1974, Somalia prior to 1969, or Lebanon today—are likely to lead to intensified conflict, institutional paralysis, and prolonged violence.

At the same time, the historical and geographic reality of the land helps explain why full separation has consistently proven unworkable. Unlike the relatively clear strategic boundaries that underpin peace agreements between Israel and its neighbors—such as the Sinai desert between Israel and Egypt or the Jordan River between Israel and Jordan—this is a single, continuous space with no natural features capable of sustaining a meaningful division. Cities, infrastructure, and populations are deeply interwoven, and perhaps more importantly, both peoples maintain an intimate historical, cultural, and religious attachment to the entirety of the land.

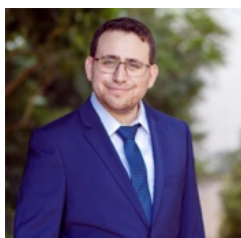
For Israeli-Jews and Palestinian-Arabs alike, the landscape is not merely territory but a lived and remembered homeland, one they aspire to access, move through, and experience freely. As a result, any attempt to impose rigid separation without mechanisms of connection risks colliding with these deeply rooted attachments, generating friction rather than stability. This is precisely why most serious proposals have sought to reconcile sovereignty with freedom of movement and shared access, allowing each people to preserve its national and religious identity while acknowledging the indivisible character of the land they inhabit.

This logic also points to the need to expand the regional dimension of peace beyond its historical scope. Frameworks such as the Gulf Cooperation Council demonstrate that regional coordination in areas like economics, security, and mobility is both possible and sustainable over time. A future Israeli–Palestinian political arrangement—whether confederal or federal in nature—could serve as a nucleus for a broader regional architecture, gradually extending cooperation across the Levant and beyond. After all, the conflict has never been purely local; its dynamics, alliances, and consequences have always been regional, which is why nearly all major peace initiatives have taken the wider Middle Eastern context into account. Yet unlike earlier models such as Pan-Arabism, this emerging framework must be consciously inclusive. It must recognize not only Arab and Muslim identities but also the rights and presence of non-Arab and non-Muslim communities—Jews, Kurds, Assyrians, Chaldeans, Circassians, Turkmen, Armenians, Maronites, Yezidis and others. In doing so, it would mark a clear departure from homogenizing and often exclusionary ideologies associated with movements like the Arab Socialist Ba'ath Party, and instead offer a federal vision in which the Middle East's diversity becomes a source of strength rather than division.

In this context, the concept of “federal bridges” emerges not merely as a technical arrangement, but as a strategic doctrine for peace-building at both the local and regional levels. Rather than forcing an immediate and fragile resolution, these bridges create a gradual process of alignment—linking Israeli and Palestinian societies, while simultaneously opening pathways for integration with the wider Middle East. By embedding cooperation in essential domains such as security, economy, infrastructure, and governance, they transform the relationship from one of zero-sum competition into one of structured interdependence that can extend outward into regional frameworks. In doing so, they serve as a safeguard against the destructive dynamics that have historically driven the conflict, ensuring that neither side can “devour” the other without simultaneously destabilizing a broader network of shared interests. Instead of separation that breeds hostility or forced unity that breeds domination, federal bridges cultivate a middle path: a layered

system of cooperation that begins locally and scales regionally. This creates not only a united front for Israeli–Palestinian peace, but also a foundation for wider regional stability—one resilient enough to contain tensions, flexible enough to evolve, and capable of transforming rivalry into sustained cooperation across the Middle East. In this way, we replace exclusionary ultra-nationalist visions—whether in the form of Pan-Arabism or maximalist interpretations of Zionism—with a model grounded in unity through diversity across the entire Middle East.

Ultimately, the path forward does not lie in choosing between rigid separation and forced unity, but in constructing a flexible and evolving framework that reflects the realities of the land and the region. The idea of “federal bridges” offers precisely such a pathway: one that preserves national self-determination while embedding it within structures of cooperation, interdependence, and regional integration. By building these connections gradually—on the ground, in institutions, and across borders—we can move beyond zero-sum thinking and toward a shared political horizon. In doing so, peace is no longer treated as a distant end-state, but as a continuous process of partnership, resilience, and mutual recognition across the Middle East.



Yair Gorni is a researcher of nationalism and ethnic conflict in Europe and the Middle East, and a PhD candidate in Political Science at the Hebrew University of Jerusalem. His research focuses on federalism, nationalism, and models of national autonomy in divided and post-imperial societies. He is also a policy officer of the Israeli Federal Future Movement, where he works on developing federal and confederal frameworks for conflict resolution.
